



underground system reminds you of the famous London Tube. Even the female voice on the public address system inside the train sounds similar: you almost expect her to say that the next station is Euston Square, where you used to get off every afternoon for a fortnight to cover the Global Chess League a couple of months ago.

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The match is played behind a glass wall. You could watch the action from the spectators' area from behind that wall. You are reminded of reporting on the 2013 match in Chennai, where Viswanathan Anand was dethroned as the World champion by Magnus Carlsen. Gukesh had watched that match from the stands as a seven-year-old. Anand is his mentor at the Westbridge Anand Chess Academy. He has always wanted to be the one to bring the World title back to India.

Yes, even the schoolboy's dream could come true in sport.

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The press conferences provide insights into the players' psyche and

class. Ding displays his sense of humour often. When asked about his mother, who you will always see sitting at the back row of the press conference hall, Ding says, "She wakes me up and sometimes gives me food. So she is doing her job."

Gukesh impresses with his grace. His mental coach, Paddy Upton, reminds me how Gukesh spent the first four minutes of his press conference after his triumph talking about Ding. Gukesh, on a day he squandered a winning chance and thus weakened his hopes of clinching the title, with just one round left, wishes Anand on his 55th birthday. Earlier, he congratulated Arjun Erigaisi on becoming only the 15th player to reach 2800 Elo points in FIDE rating, making former women's World champion Susan Polgar tweet how classy he is.

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People from different parts of the world have flown in to watch the match. But mostly the audience is made up of the Indian diaspora of Singapore. Like Aruna Rao, who heads HR of a multinational

Gazing eyes: The spectators watch on as the World chess championship match between Ding Liren and D. Gukesh is played behind a glass wall.

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company, and her little son Surya, who catch your attention inside the spectators' area as they replay the moves of Gukesh on their small wooden chessboard — and not on the phone or the tab.

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It is not every day as a sports journalist that you get to report on a truly historic moment. As the flight takes off from the beautiful Changi airport on a pleasant night, you reflect on Gukesh's remarkable triumph.

This time, you are glad to know there will not be a cyclone in Chennai. So you could land there — Gukesh would also arrive there five hours after you do — on your way back to Kozhikode. There will be no need to travel by road to another airport like Coimbatore, something you had to do to reach Singapore.